

frequencies that are created by the source of the distortion. The battle was closely fought—the Audigy Platinum, the Sound Blaster Live! Value, the Extigy and the Live! DE 5.1, each scored within 0.0044 per cent of each other. The Vibra 128 generated a disappointing score of 32.0379 per cent.

e) **Stereo Cross talk:** The last of our tests estimates signal leakages from one channel to another. If a sound device has a poor score here, you might not be able to get good stereo sound. Once again, the Extigy stood tall in front of its competitors with a score of -104 dB, while the Vibra fared the worst with -34.8 dB.

Warranty and support

Soundcards hardly experience problems that require servicing; the only major concern is getting the right drivers for the operating system used. But given the price of some of the cards available, extended warranty life is a reassuring benefit. Most of the vendors provide a flat one-year warranty, which we think is a bit less. Consider the case of the Audigy Platinum and the Creative Extigy. With their prices being on the higher side, the number of years for which the product is warranted against manufacturing defects gets more critical than having a greater number of service centres. Service centres, however, have a pretty decent coverage: the Creative series of soundcards being distributed by Compuage Infocom has 18 service centres in 18 cities. The Zoltrix Nightingale PRO 6 has only eight service centres across two cities—a stumbling block for potential buyers. We feel that users will be served better if vendors extend the warranty period of these products.

Buying Tips

- Define your usage. If you are an avid music lover, go for a soundcard that supports multiple channels. If you want a gaming solution, buy a card that supports the standard 3D APIs, viz., DirectSound, EAX, A3D and I3DL2.
- The vendor should provide a minimum one-year warranty for budget soundcards (under Rs 2,000) and at least a three-year warranty for costlier variants.
- Before buying, make sure that the soundcard's interface is PCI or USB and not ISA. If you plan to use your soundcard for playing games or watching DVD movies, get a PCI soundcard.
- See to it that the soundcard you are buying has drivers for your favourite operating system. Users of Microsoft Windows should not face problems, but the requisite drivers for the Linux OS for example, might be hard to come by.
- If you are an audiophile and appreciate minimum signal loss, buy a soundcard that uses gold-plated connectors.
- Check to see if the soundcard comes bundled with a decent variety of applications (such as games and media players). If you are a first time buyer, these will prove to be very essential to get the most out of your purchase.

Decision Maker			
You want	A basic, no-frills sound-card	Surround sound at an affordable price	Excellent sound quality for professional level editing
Look for	A full-duplex card or a motherboard with an on-board sound chip that provides simple stereo or 2.1 channel output	A card with 4.1 or 5.1 channel support. In-built Dolby Digital decoding will be an added bonus	A card that supports 24-bit recording at 96 KHz along with connectors like S/PDIF, DIN or FireWire
Your options	AD1981A-based motherboard or Creative Vibra 128	Creative Sound Blaster Live! DE 5.1 or Zoltrix Nightingale PRO 6	Creative Audigy Platinum or Creative Sound Blaster Extigy
Price range	Up to Rs 1,000 (for external soundcard)	Rs 2,000 to Rs 2,700	Above Rs 10,000

What it all leads to

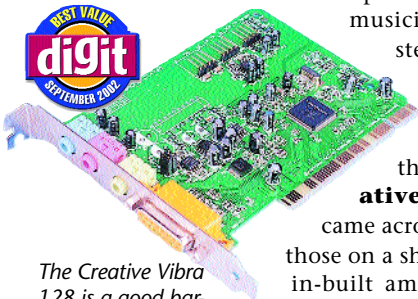
Soundcards have come of age. The quality of sound offered by the majority of these cards is good enough to satiate the casual listener, while the high-end products are guaranteed to impress even the most discerning audiophile. The Zoltrix Nightingale PRO 6 fought hard against the Extigy, scoring a 26.77 in the performance test, compared to Extigy's 25.16 points. However, the Creative cards walked away with all the accolades.

The Best Performance Award goes to the **Creative Audigy Platinum**, which edged out its nearest rival, the Creative Sound Blaster Live! DE 5.1. This card provides good quality thanks to the 24-bit sound playback depth and its support for 5.1-channel sound. Moreover, it put the least amount of stress on the system (only 1.59 per cent CPU utilisation) and produced good noise and cross talk attenuation scores. A bunch of accessories including an external Audigy drive that has FireWire support along with an entire gamut of connectors for pure digital sound. It also comes bundled with good sound and video editing tools like FruityLoops 3, Ulead VideoStudio and Acid Style 2.0—an excellent solution for an audiophile as well as a professional musician. But its price is a bit steep at Rs 13,915.

The Best Value Award went to yet another product from the Creative stable. The **Creative Vibra 128**, at Rs 966, came across as an ideal solution for those on a shoestring budget. It has an in-built amplifier for the Line Out port, which might be a boon to those with non-amplified speakers. The sound quality was also quite acceptable; it scored 2.03 and 3 points under the sound track and the gaming test, respectively.



Creative Audigy Platinum, a real treat with excellent sound clarity



The Creative Vibra 128 is a good bargain for the non-discerning user